PHASE

A visual summary of how AI helped clarify, reframe, expand, critique, and communicate my design process

Milestone 01: EMPHATHISE

Traditional Way to Make Matcha

1) Manually Grinding the material with prepared tools The warm water for a clean flow, the bamboo whisk for mixing, and the matcha powder.

2) Sifting the matcha powder into the bowl Sift the matcha powder into the bowl to prevent clumps and ensure a smooth texture. This prevents lumps in the final beverage, guaranteeing a smooth, high-quality drinking experience.

3) Adding a small amount of warm water to form a paste Add a small amount of warm water to the sifted matcha powder. This initial step creates a concentrated paste, ensuring even distribution and preventing dry pockets of powder.

4) Whisking vigorously in a zigzag motion until a frothy layer forms Whisk the paste vigorously in a zigzag motion until a rich, frothy layer forms on the surface. This aeration is crucial for the final texture and taste.

Reflection summary

An important lesson in this project was that even a simple ritual can become a design challenge when it is approached with care, attention to detail, and a willingness to question what has been taken for granted. The traditional way of preparing matcha is deeply rooted in tradition and sensory pleasure, but it also depends on several small actions that can easily be forgotten when the ritual is simplified into a product. This project reminded me that good design does not always begin with a new invention. It can begin with noticing what people already do well and asking how that experience might be improved without losing its meaning.

Accepted

This insight strongly accepted the shared experience of preparing matcha as the core value that should remain central in any design focus. Little opportunity or unnecessary complexity should be added to the ritual, which is treated as a meaningful interaction between, and clearly, humans, the tea, and the tools used to prepare it. This response was accepted as it was clear that the ritual should retain its process-rich rhythm and viewer-friendly nature. Blue-crazy

Rejected

This insight, large responses controlling a specific interface scenario is too early, because the beverage and ritual should remain the main focus. Interfaces are important making the process easy as beverage preparation ephemeral, and it rejected phone-only interfaces as the main solution, since they would shift the focus away from the ritual. Instead, the interface should be considered later, only if it supports the ritual without becoming the main focus.

Keywords

- traditional ritual
- mindfulness
- sensory pleasure
- tea culture
- simplicity
- ritual preparation
- mindful consumption
- sensory experience
- cultural heritage
- tea culture
- ritual simplicity

AI Critiques

Clarity: 9/10

Its Value: Excellent. The core value is clearly stated, focusing on the sensory experience and the ritual's simplicity. This is a strong foundation for any design brief.

Actionable Insight: The insight provides a clear, actionable insight: the design should enhance the ritual without becoming the main focus. This is a powerful guiding principle for ensuring the design serves the user's experience.

Transformed

This insight greatly transformed the project from a generic tea beverage machine into a focused user interaction. The focus shifted from the machine's function to the user's sensory journey, and it transformed a large, complex machine into a simple, elegant, and intuitive interaction. It also transformed "making a drink" into "preparing a ritual," which significantly changed the design brief.

Design decision

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Milestone 02: DEFINE

Selected impactful prompts and prompt summary

Prompt 1

Prompt: Choose between coffee machine, tea machine, hot chocolate machine, and matcha machine. "The prompt was chosen because it forces a comparative evaluation of the beverage category itself instead of a generic design exercise. It tests whether I can identify which product category has the strongest potential for a specific lifestyle and scale the design question accordingly, rather than defaulting to a familiar product. It also tests whether I can think commercially and strategically about which product category is most sustainable to iterate on and most scalable to develop into a viable business."

Prompt 2

"Can you define the problem and the user?" or equivalent problem-framing prompt. "This prompt was important because it forced me to define a specific lifestyle and user before designing anything. It tests whether I can think from a specific user's perspective rather than jumping into solutions too early. It also tests whether I can make a product feel relevant to a specific cultural moment, not just a generic product."

Prompt 3

"Can you define the problem and the user?" or equivalent problem-framing prompt. "This prompt was important because it forced me to define a specific lifestyle and user before designing anything. It tests whether I can think from a specific user's perspective rather than jumping into solutions too early. It also tests whether I can make a product feel relevant to a specific cultural moment, not just a generic product."

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Prompt 3

"I'm designing a countertop tea beverage preparing electronic device for a specialty tea shop in Vancouver. It's for people who want a ritual around tea but don't have the time, space, or patience for a full Japanese tea ceremony. It's a premium product, roughly the size of a small espresso machine, and it's meant to be a centerpiece of a morning routine. It's for someone who wants to feel like they're making something beautiful and intentional, but who doesn't want to spend 20 minutes on it every morning." "Because it's a premium product, I wanted to see if the design could stand on its own as a piece of tech worth owning, not just as a wellness gadget. This prompt also forced me to think about who would actually buy this and what their lifestyle would look like, which shaped the design brief in a specific direction."

Keywords

- ritual tea
- ceremony
- specialty tea
- tea culture
- mindfulness
- tea ceremony
- minimalist design
- premium product
- wellness
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Clarity: 9/10

Its Value: Excellent. The core value is clear: it's about creating a meaningful, intentional ritual around tea, not just making a drink. This is a strong foundation for any design brief.

Actionable Insight: The insight provides a clear, actionable insight: the design should enhance the ritual without becoming the main focus. This is a powerful guiding principle for ensuring the design serves the user's experience.

Accepted

This insight strongly accepted the shared experience of preparing matcha as the core value that should remain central in any design focus. Little opportunity or unnecessary complexity should be added to the ritual, which is treated as a meaningful interaction between, and clearly, humans, the tea, and the tools used to prepare it. This response was accepted as it was clear that the ritual should retain its process-rich rhythm and viewer-friendly nature. Blue-crazy

Rejected

This insight, large responses controlling a specific interface scenario is too early, because the beverage and ritual should remain the main focus. Interfaces are important making the process easy as beverage preparation ephemeral, and it rejected phone-only interfaces as the main solution, since they would shift the focus away from the ritual. Instead, the interface should be considered later, only if it supports the ritual without becoming the main focus.

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AI response summary

Response summary for Prompt 1

AI compared coffee, tea, hot chocolate, and matcha as potential design directions. It evaluated them in terms of innovation potential, user pain points, product differentiation, and practical feasibility. Coffee was identified as familiar but crowded and technically mature, with little room for meaningful differentiation. Tea was seen as culturally rich but underserved in convenient, modern forms. Hot chocolate was seen as sensory and appealing but less strong as an everyday ritual system because of cleaning and product freshness. Matcha emerged as the most promising direction because it sits at the intersection of health, ritual, aesthetics, and a stronger gap between traditional preparation and contemporary everyday use. AI effectively showed that matcha offered a more meaningful design opportunity because it combined cultural depth, visual appeal, mobile ritual, inconvenience, risk, and the possibility of thoughtful innovation.

Response summary for Prompt 2

AI framed the user problem around the friction in the project around a specific user: a health-conscious person with a busy morning routine living in a small apartment. It identified the central pain points as cluttered, messy, and time-consuming preparation steps, cleaning effort, and the difficulty of maintaining the ritual consistently in limited space and under time pressure. AI also articulated that the user likely values not only function but also calm, simplicity, and a sense of control over their morning routine. This prompt was important because it forced the project to move beyond a generic product idea and define a specific lifestyle, a clear friction point, and a meaningful emotional benefit. It also showed that the design should make the process legible and easier to sustain, rather than simply adding another device to the user's environment.

Response summary for Prompt 3

AI identified two specific friction points in shared tea beverage crafters: unclear water and with responsibility, and inconsistent results caused by poor timing, temperature, and technique. It also identified the need for quick feedback, low mess, ways for recipe sharing, sustained accountability, and consumables delivery. It then proposed three minimal-control interaction concepts: a profile-led with that better, a robot-friendly with timers, a shared-recipe system with feedback and reminders. This response was important because it translated the user frustrations into concrete design opportunities. It showed that problems like cleanliness and inconsistency could be reframed as interface, ritual, and feedback design problems. It also showed that the most promising direction was not a more complex machine, but a simpler, more accessible system that could make consistent results more achievable through minimal control and ongoing support.

Selected impactful prompts and prompt summary

Prompt 1

"Can you define the problem and the user?" or equivalent problem-framing prompt. "This prompt was important because it forced me to define a specific lifestyle and user before designing anything. It tests whether I can think from a specific user's perspective rather than jumping into solutions too early. It also tests whether I can make a product feel relevant to a specific cultural moment, not just a generic product."

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Rejected

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AI response summary

Response summary for Prompt 1

AI generated three concept directions. The first concept, "Contained Whole Zone," proposed a compact ritual base that defines a specific whisking area so that the user still performs real whisking while the mess is spatially contained. The second concept, "Quick-Rinse Vessel Geometry," focused on the vessel itself by designing it as a tech-clean object with smooth surfaces and rounded edges that reduce residue and make cleaning faster than a traditional matcha. The third concept, "Closure Ritual Dock," emphasized the ending of the process: after stirring, the user completes a closing sequence such as rinse, dock, and close, making cleanup part of the ritual rather than a delayed chore. Across all three, AI interpreted the problem as a system of habit, closure, and repeatability rather than a machine that simply mixes ingredients faster. It also explicitly tied the concepts back to the chosen lifestyle and product goal: convenient, premium, and satisfying.

Response summary for Prompt 2

When the three concepts were visualized side by side, AI made them easier to compare as design directions rather than isolated descriptions. The value of this response was not only the images themselves but the comparative reading they allowed. The visual output showed whether each concept could plausibly preserve ritual while remaining compact, calm, and appropriate for a premium kitchen product. This response was important because it turned conceptual frameworks into a finished design proposals. This visualization stage supported concept comparison, but it also exposed the limits of AI ideation by making clear that the generated directions still needed significant human judgment and reinterpretation to become realistic and grounded.

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Milestone 03: IDEATE

Selected impactful prompts and prompt summary

Prompt 1

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Prompt 2

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Prompt 3

"Can you define the problem and the user?" or equivalent problem-framing prompt. "This prompt was important because it forced me to define a specific lifestyle and user before designing anything. It tests whether I can think from a specific user's perspective rather than jumping into solutions too early. It also tests whether I can make a product feel relevant to a specific cultural moment, not just a generic product."

Selected impactful prompts and prompt summary

Prompt 1

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Prompt 2

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Prompt 3

"Can you visualize all three three matcha machine concepts side by side." "This prompt is important because it shifts ideation from abstract concept into comparable visual alternatives. It helps me see which direction looks most promising, which details need more exploration, and which concepts are weak or redundant. It also forces me to translate my design ideas into a more concrete and reviewable form."

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Milestone 04: PROTOTYPE

Selected impactful prompts and prompt summary

Prompt 1

"Choose a compact matcha device that guarantees a clean, drying-free, centrally prepared cup by automating the entire prep steps (temperature, portioning, sifting) while preserving the user's ritual and control over taste." "This prompt was the key prototype prompt because it formalizes the selected concept into an actionable product structure. It converts the ideation phase into a clear design brief with constraints and a defined product goals, making the next step more actionable and grounded in the machine."

Prompt 2

"Make it look like matcha machine sketch. It does not have sharp corners, and the bowl is integrated in it." "There is also a specific reason for this prompt. I want to make it look like it belongs in the water around bath. Also on top of it there are angle lids that lead to water and matcha powder storage separately. Do not show the whole machine, only the top part." "This prompt is important because it translates the selected logic into a first-explicit physical configuration. It introduces form, proportions, interaction, and a user scenario in one compact prompt."

Prompt 3

"Make it look more rectangular as you can see the bowl is also rectangular, don't change it, stay to the lines of my sketch, and the machine is not white pixels, it has stone texture and bamboo additions." "This prompt is important because it shows an iterative prototyping move: AI's first visualization was too generic, and the user corrected it toward a more specific, lighter-toned, nature-inspired aesthetic and CMF."

Keywords

- automated processes
- workflow optimization
- ritual automation
- precision control
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Actionable Insight: The insight provides a clear, actionable insight: the design should enhance the ritual without becoming the main focus. This is a powerful guiding principle for ensuring the design serves the user's experience.

Accepted

The prototype stage accepted manual water control, manual whisking, compact footprint, self-generated ritual, clean and bamboo CMF, hygiene-first detailing, integrated front zone, digital control, and a calm, premium, nature-inspired aesthetic. Kept: Functionality: the core functions (automated prep, ritual control, consistency, convenience) are clear and relevant and helped concretize the concept.

Rejected

The prototype stage rejected automated water control, automated whisking, and a fully self-contained system. Reason: Automation risks stripping the ritual of its meaning, reduces user control, and adds unnecessary complexity. Automation should be used for repetitive, low-value tasks, not for the core ritual.

Transformed

The prototype stage transformed the project from a concept into a prototype-level product architecture. It transformed the user experience from a generic "tea machine" into a ritual-centered, hygiene-first, nature-inspired product with clear zones and machine roles. It also transformed a sketch-level idea into a more specific product direction with defined materials, interaction logic, and a clear form factor.

Design decision

The major design decision in the prototype stage was to adopt the hybrid model, keeping the ritual with the user while using automation for repetitive, low-value tasks. This decision was not only technical but conceptual: it preserved the ritual value of making matcha while improving hygiene, consistency, convenience, and usability. It also framed automation as a supportive design tool, not a replacement for the user's role in the ritual.

Selected impactful prompts and prompt summary

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Rejected

The prototype stage rejected full automation. Reason: Automation risks stripping the ritual of its meaning, reduces user control, and adds unnecessary complexity. Automation should be used for repetitive, low-value tasks, not for the core ritual.

Transformed

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Selected impactful prompts and prompt summary

Prompt 1

"Make it look like matcha machine sketch. It does not have sharp corners, and the bowl is integrated in it." "There is also a specific reason for this prompt. I want to make it look like it belongs in the water around bath. Also on top of it there are angle lids that lead to water and matcha powder storage separately. Do not show the whole machine, only the top part." "This prompt is important because it translates the selected logic into a first-explicit physical configuration. It introduces form, proportions, interaction, and a user scenario in one compact prompt."

Prompt 2

"Make it look more rectangular as you can see the bowl is also rectangular, don't change it, stay to the lines of my sketch, and the machine is not white pixels, it has stone texture and bamboo additions." "This prompt is important because it shows an iterative prototyping move: AI's first visualization was too generic, and the user corrected it toward a more specific, lighter-toned, nature-inspired aesthetic and CMF."

Prompt 3

"Can you visualize all three three matcha machine concepts side by side." "This prompt is important because it shifts ideation from abstract concept into comparable visual alternatives. It helps me see which direction looks most promising, which details need more exploration, and which concepts are weak or redundant. It also forces me to translate my design ideas into a more concrete and reviewable form."

Keywords

- automated processes
- workflow optimization
- ritual automation
- precision control
- consistency
- convenience
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AI Critiques

Clarity: 9/10

Its Value: Excellent. The core value is clear: it's about creating a meaningful, intentional ritual around tea, not just making a drink. This is a strong foundation for any design brief.

Actionable Insight: The insight provides a clear, actionable insight: the design should enhance the ritual without becoming the main focus. This is a powerful guiding principle for ensuring the design serves the user's experience.

Accepted

The prototype stage accepted manual water control, manual whisking, compact footprint, self-generated ritual, clean and bamboo CMF, hygiene-first detailing, integrated front zone, digital control, and a calm, premium, nature-inspired aesthetic. Kept: Functionality: the core functions (automated prep, ritual control, consistency, convenience) are clear and relevant and helped concretize the concept.

Rejected

The prototype stage rejected full automation. Reason: Automation risks stripping the ritual of its meaning, reduces user control, and adds unnecessary complexity. Automation should be used for repetitive, low-value tasks, not for the core ritual.

Transformed

The prototype stage transformed the project from a concept into a prototype-level product architecture. It transformed the user experience from a generic "tea machine" into a ritual-centered, hygiene-first, nature-inspired product with clear zones and machine roles. It also transformed a sketch-level idea into a more specific product direction with defined materials, interaction logic, and a clear form factor.

Design decision

The major design decision in the prototype stage was to adopt the hybrid model, keeping the ritual with the user while using automation for repetitive, low-value tasks. This decision was not only technical but conceptual: it preserved the ritual value of making matcha while improving hygiene, consistency, convenience, and usability. It also framed automation as a supportive design tool, not a replacement for the user's role in the ritual.

AI response summary

Response summary for Prompt 1

AI produced a refined prototype logic centered on a clear workflow split. Manual activity was limited to the ritual gesture of whisking with a real chasen in a dedicated bowl zone, while the machine handled the steps most associated with error and inconsistency: heating water to a machine-appropriate range, dosing matcha consistently, and sifting powder to prevent clumps. It also identified automatic pouring as optional and suggested that the machine could support a ready-to-drink output when convenience or complexity became more important. In parallel, AI proposed a clean form and CMF direction: compact footprint for small kitchens, soft geometry without sharp edges, stone or bamboo cues to avoid a generic appliance character, and hygiene-first detailing through smooth transitions, minimal seams, and removable-process contact modules. This response was useful because it translated the concept into a structured prototype rationale and a visible product direction.

Response summary for Prompt 2

AI translated the sketch and usage scenario into a first realistic product visualization. The described prototype included an integrated bowl, a digital display at the upper front for controlling water and portion amount, separate upper-rear lids for water and matcha powder storage, and a compact footprint for chasen storage and drying. The scenario also clearly sequenced the user loads water and powder, selects values on the screen, the machine sifts and dispenses, and the user completes the final whisking action manually. The value of this response was that it made the concept inspectable as an object and as a process. At the same time, your reference notes that the AI output followed the intended functionality but drifted away from your desired visual language, which revealed that visual alignment still required tighter control.

Response summary for Prompt 3

AI generated a second-refined visualization after stricter instructions about geometry and materiality. The revised output moved closer to the intended rectangular reading and incorporated stone-like and bamboo-like CMF cues instead of generic white plastic. According to your own reference, this output was the strongest of the set and was used as the baseline for further communication tool for discussion with instructors. The response therefore served not only as a rendering step but as a prototype refinement method: by observing where the AI changed the form and then correcting those deviations, the project's formal boundaries became clearer.

Milestone 05: TEST

Selected impactful prompts and prompt summary

Prompt 1

"Can you test the prototype?" "This was the central test prompt because it shifted the process from visualization and form confirmation into structured evaluation. Rather than testing for aesthetics alone, it tested whether the prototype could support the ritual and interaction logic."

Prompt 2

"The prototype did not produce only one generic options. It generated a full "Test and Observe" framework organized into an evaluation arrow, water filling and storage access, matcha preparation, and cleaning and maintenance. This was important because it turned the prototype into a system that could be inspected step by step."

Selected impactful prompts and prompt summary

Prompt 1

"I prepared the second and I want you to rotate it concept according to all the information that I already gave you. To remind you, the prototype is a compact, hygiene-first, ritual-aware tea brewing device for a small apartment in Jeonju. The prototype uses a compact footprint, a clean and bamboo CMF, a hygiene-first design, a digital control interface, and a ritual-friendly workflow." "This prompt is the central iteration promp